

BIRDS OF PREY

The largest and most important group of day-flying hunters, almost all the birds in the order Accipitriformes are exclusively meat-eaters. In some habitats they are the top predators.

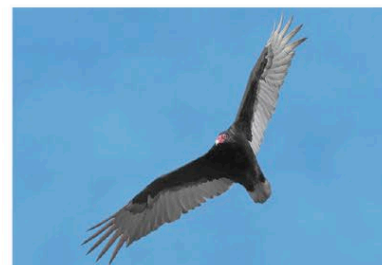
Large birds of prey, such as the harpy eagle and Philippine eagle of tropical rainforests, are so powerful they can kill large monkeys and small deer. The largest species, which include Old World vultures and American condors, feed on dead animals, and many, such as kites and buzzards, eat carrion as well as catch live prey. Exceptions include the largely vegetarian palm-nut vulture of Africa.

Birds of prey typically have keen vision and hunt by sight. The turkey vulture detects prey by smell, and other species watch and follow it down to hidden carcasses. Birds in this group have a strong, hooked bill for dismembering prey. Larger vultures are well-equipped to rip hide

and flesh but have relatively weak feet. Most have a bare head, which prevents an unhygienic, sticky mess when probing inside animal carcasses. New World vultures may be more closely related to storks than to the similar-looking Old World vultures. Eagles, hawks, buzzards, and kites have stronger feet with long, curved, sharp claws, used for catching and killing prey. The unique secretary bird of African plains hunts on foot.

Some kites have a forked tail for greater control in flight. Bird-eating hawks have rather short wings and a long tail, for extra manoeuvrability through woodland, while other species have longer, broader wings that allow them to soar on rising air currents and glide long distances with little effort. In this way, heavy vultures can move very long distances to find food each day, and some species perform very long annual migrations. Their “fingered” wingtips reduce turbulence at the wingtip, giving greater efficiency.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	ACCIPITRIFORMES
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	266



The pale underwings of a turkey vulture catch the sunlight as it tilts, twists, and turns, searching for food below.



64–81 cm
25–32 in

TURKEY VULTURE

Cathartes aura
F: Cathartidae

Unusually for birds, this widespread American vulture locates rotting carcasses by smell. It often nests in dark recesses, such as under large rocks or stumps.



67–81 cm
26–32 in

contrasting black
and white wings

KING VULTURE

Sarcoramphus papa
F: Cathartidae

This large bird soars high above forests of tropical America looking for carrion. It is distinguished by its colourful head and fleshy bill wattle.



56–66 cm
22–26 in

BLACK VULTURE

Coragyps atratus
F: Cathartidae

More gregarious than the related turkey vulture, the black vulture is an opportunistic scavenger found from the C. USA to Chile.



white streaks
on massive wings

ANDEAN CONDOR

Vultur gryphus
F: Cathartidae

S. America's largest flying land bird, this species soars on updraughts in the Andes, locating carrion by sight or by following other scavengers, such as turkey vultures.